

Storytelling - Building institutional capacity for climate reporting: Serbia's experience

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Serbia's experience in institutional capacity building for climate reporting started with the adoption of the Law on Climate Change, which introduced new responsibilities for the Climate Change Department. In parallel, Serbia, as an EU candidate country and a Contracting Party to the Energy Community, took on a growing number of reporting obligations, including new reporting requirements linked to the Governance Regulation.

At the time these obligations were introduced, the Climate Change Department had a limited number of staff, already responsible for a wide range of policy, legislative and coordination tasks. New reporting responsibilities therefore had to be introduced into an already demanding institutional setting, with limited human resources and different levels of technical knowledge across the institutions involved.

A key turning point was the introduction of reporting obligations under the Governance Regulation. This required Serbia to identify the exact reporting requirements, clarify which institutions were responsible for which elements, define roles and responsibilities, and establish a practical coordination mechanism. The process also revealed several challenges, including unclear division of competences between institutions, capacity gaps, limited technical knowledge and the need for stronger institutional continuity.

Despite these challenges, Serbia completed the first reporting process relatively successfully and fulfilled its reporting obligations through ReportNet and ReportEner. This helped establish a basis for cooperation between institutions and showed the importance of clear coordination, practical learning and continuous communication.

The experience also showed that further strengthening of the legal and institutional framework is necessary. Serbia is currently working on amendments to the reporting rulebook related to the Integrated National Energy and Climate Plan, with the aim of addressing identified gaps and making the reporting system more structured and sustainable.

The main lesson from Serbia's experience is that capacity building is a continuous process. It does not end with one training or one reporting cycle. It requires clear legal rules, defined institutional responsibilities, stable coordination mechanisms, continuous learning, and measures to preserve institutional knowledge even when trained staff leave. Climate reporting obligations can therefore serve not only as a technical requirement, but also as an important driver for broader institutional reform.

A further important message from Serbia's experience is that it is better to start implementing new reporting obligations as early as possible, even when the system is not fully in place. Reporting is a learning-by-doing process, and each cycle helps institutions better understand the requirements, identify gaps and improve coordination. External support has been very important in this process, including the project support and trainings organized by the EEA. This type of support is particularly valuable because climate and energy reporting is complex and involves many institutions and reporting streams — in Serbia's case, around 15 to 20 institutions and experts contribute to different parts of the reporting process. In-country support is especially useful, as it allows a larger number of people from different institutions to be trained together, improves mutual understanding, and helps build a more sustainable national reporting system.